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Columbia College Core Curriculum

CONTEMPORARY CIVILIZATION

COCI 1101, Section 030

Fall 2026

4 credits

Mon Wed 4:10 pm – 6:00 pm

205 Broadway Residence Hall

COURSE DESCRIPTION

The central purpose of Contemporary Civilization is to introduce students to a range of issues concerning the kinds of communities—political, social, moral, and religious—that human beings construct for themselves, and the values that inform and define such communities. Founded in 1919 as a course on war and peace issues, Contemporary Civilization has evolved continuously while remaining a constant and essential element of the Columbia College curriculum. The course asks students to read closely texts in various traditions of argument and to construct arguments of their own, both in speech and in writing, about some of the explicit and implicit issues that these texts raise.

Contemporary Civilization asks where political authority comes from and what we owe each other. We read primary texts in political and moral philosophy not as monuments but as arguments, and we hold them to account. This section organizes the whole semester around that single question, which every text on our list answers differently.

Two working norms follow. First, we read every text as political theory, scripture included. When we take up Exodus, the Gospels, Romans, and the Qur'an, we ask what they claim about founding, law, obligation, and community, and we hold apart the separate question of whether they are true. That is a norm of analysis rather than a statement about anyone's faith, and it applies to Plato exactly as it applies to Paul. Second, the seminar runs on your argument, not on my lecture. Come having read closely enough to put a finger on a passage and say what it does. Class time is for disagreement conducted with evidence, which is also, not coincidentally, what the course is about.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of the semester, students should be able to:

- Reconstruct an argument from a primary text in its own terms: its central claim, the premises it rests on, and the objections it anticipates.
- Explain how the major texts on our list answer the question that runs through the course, where political authority comes from and what we owe each other, and locate precisely where their answers diverge.
- Read texts from unfamiliar traditions, scriptural and philosophical alike, with the same analytic attention, holding apart what a text claims from whether it is true.
- Put two texts into genuine argument with each other rather than summarizing them in sequence.
- Take a position in seminar discussion, support it from a specific passage, and revise it under objection.

POLICIES

Attendance

This is a seminar, so your presence and your preparation are the course itself. I expect you at every meeting, with the reading done before you arrive. If you pass two absences of any kind, I will check in with you, and the Core also asks me to notify your Advising Dean, because a run of missed classes is often a sign that something else is going on. More than **three** unexcused absences will lower your final grade by one step, so that a B becomes a B–. **Five** unexcused absences will result in an automatic failure of the course.

Excused absences are limited to reasons protected by University policy, chiefly religious observance and Disability Services accommodations. They do not count toward the totals above, and they are the only absences for which I offer make-up work. Please tell me in advance so that we can set it up, and for a religious holiday tell me at the start of the semester if you can, since the fall calendar holds several.

Course-Specific Policies

Contemporary Civilization is a seminar that depends largely on what happens between us in the room: sharing ideas, listening carefully to one another, remaining focused and thoughtful, and thinking out loud together about the texts we are reading. Screens work against that. They distract the person using them and everyone sitting nearby. **For these reasons, electronic devices are prohibited in Contemporary Civilization classes. Laptops, tablets, and phones should be silenced and put away for the duration of our meetings.** Please bring hard copies of the assigned readings and a notebook to class. If there is an occasion when I want us to use devices for an in-class activity, I will tell you in advance. **If**

you have a compelling reason for needing a device in class, please speak with me and we will work out an approach that works for you.

Use of Generative AI

This course treats generative AI the way the policy world does: as a tool you should know how to use, and one you may not outsource your judgment to. You may use generative AI tools to check and correct language mistakes; to generate ideas and facilitate brainstorming; to locate sources; and to clarify concepts from the readings. However, submitting AI-generated prose or analysis as your own work is plagiarism under the Core's ratified integrity policy and the Faculty Statement on Academic Integrity. The argument, the analysis, and the final wording of everything you submit must be yours.

If you use AI on work you submit, add a short note at the end of it telling me three things: which tool you used, what you used it for, and what you changed afterward. Two or three sentences is usually enough. If AI shaped the substance of the work rather than just the wording, include the exchange itself, or the parts of it that mattered.

I will not run your work through AI-detection tools: they are unreliable and biased against non-native English speakers. You should expect to explain and defend any part of what you submit, in class or in conversation with me; inability to do so will be treated as evidence that the work is not your own.

Academic Honesty and Integrity

There has been a marked increase in incidents of plagiarism in Core, which has led the deans and chairs of the Core curriculum to draft and ratify the following policy:

“Columbia College is dedicated to the highest ideals of integrity in academia. Therefore, in Literature Humanities and Contemporary Civilization, any instance of academic dishonesty, attempted or actual, will be reported to the faculty chair of the course and to the dean of the Core Curriculum, who will review the case with the expectation that a student guilty of academic dishonesty may receive the grade of ‘F’ in the course and be referred to dean's discipline for further institutional action.”

Plagiarism includes:

- Submitting of written responses, essays, or portions of essays, written by other people as one's own.
- Failing to acknowledge, through footnotes and bibliographic references, the source of ideas, words, or structures of argumentation essentially not one's own.
- Failing to indicate paraphrases or ideas or expressions (verbatim or modified) not one's own through proper use of quotations and footnotes.
- Submitting an essay written for one course to a second course without having sought prior permission from both instructors.

Because this course focuses on your direct interaction with the readings, there is no need to consult secondary sources, but if you do choose to use them, you must always use proper citation. You must also always cite appropriate references to primary texts.

Academic Accommodations

Columbia's Disability Services (DS) office administers all academic accommodations. If you have a DS-certified Accommodation Letter, send it to me early in the semester and come to office hours so we can confirm what you need and how it will work in a seminar. If you think you may have a disability that requires accommodation and are not yet registered, contact Disability Services at 212-854-2388 or disability@columbia.edu. I am glad to talk with you in the meantime, but the certification has to come from them. What you tell me about a disability stays with me. Separately, and whether or not a formal accommodation is involved, if something about how this course runs is getting in the way of your learning, tell me and we will work on it.

GRADING

Students must meet all course requirements to receive a passing grade. Your grade is made up of five components:

<i>Component</i>	<i>Weight</i>
Participation	20%
Essay Assignments (two, 15% each)	30%
Reading Quizzes	10%
Midterm Exam	20%
Final Exam	20%
Total:	100%

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Participation (20%)

As demonstrated by two components: 1) active and sustained engagement with the readings, the discussion, and the lectures, and 2) the Wednesday in-class writing described below. This course is designed around expectations of active and sustained engagement with the readings, and class discussions. Please allow your peers to extract a benefit from your study and insight. Students who may not be as comfortable speaking during class can make up for it through writing assignments, provided

that they have the preapproval of the instructor. If that is you, come talk to me in the first two weeks and we will agree on what the additional written work looks like.

Participation will be assessed primarily on evidence that students have completed the assigned readings and are engaging substantively with the course material. Meaningful participation may take several forms, including asking thoughtful questions, offering comments grounded in the readings or lectures, reconstructing or critiquing arguments, introducing relevant examples, and connecting course concepts to current events. The quality, relevance, and consistency of contributions will matter more than the frequency with which a student speaks. The bands below describe what that engagement looks like at each level.

- A. Consistently excellent preparation. Offers analysis and synthesis, connects threads across the discussion into new approaches, and shows command of the reading through precise citation. Regularly arrives having engaged the text in advance, evident in prepared questions and attention to specific passages.
- B. Comes prepared and makes thoughtful contributions when called on, and often without prompting. Shows interest in and respect for others' views and takes an active part in small-group work. This band also fits an eager contributor whose comments are still developing in cogency or command of the reading but that move the conversation forward.
- C. Comes prepared but rarely contributes without being called on, while remaining attentive, taking notes, and showing genuine interest; some students in this band are simply reserved. Or: participates actively but in ways that need adjustment, such as speaking at length, drifting off topic, or leaving little room for others. In either case, engagement in small-group work, visible progress over the term, and coming to office hours can raise the grade.
- D. Rarely appears engaged and contributes little. Shows limited evidence of having done the reading and takes a small part in group work.
- E. Regularly absent or unprepared, with little evidence of engagement with the course.

Participation will also include in-class writing exercises, which will be the material your two essays are built from. On Wednesdays, beginning September 16, you will write a short reflection of about two paragraphs on that session's reading and our discussion of it, and hand it in before you leave. The one Wednesday without in-class writing is October 28, the midterm. These are not graded for quality but will count toward your participation grade. Following our attendance policy, make-up opportunities will only be provided for excused absences.

Essays (30%)

There will be two essay assignments that grow out of your Wednesday writings. The first essay draws on our reading through Ibn Khaldun's *Muqaddimah*, and is due **Monday, October 26.**

Essay 2 draws on the rest of the semester, from Christine de Pizan onward, and is due **Tuesday, December 22.** The essays will be 4-5 pages each, with rubrics posted on CourseWorks.

In-class writing activities are a place to find out what you actually think about, which is often not what you expected. By late October most people notice they keep circling the same question, the same author, or the same disagreement. That is your essay. Your essay can be an argumentative development of a topic or concept that interested you most, or an analytic assessment of several texts placed in dialogue. You may also take up a discussion topic raised in class, or offer your own interpretation of a text. Whichever form you choose, the essay has to show your active effort to understand the reading and to engage with it critically. Please come to office hours at least once to look back over your weekly writing with me and talk through what you want to write about.

Reading Quizzes (10%)

There will be seven short reading quizzes throughout the semester, given without advance notice at the start of class. They will not include trick questions, mostly asking what happened in the reading rather than what it means. These are designed so that students who have completed the readings and taken notes should be able to finish comfortably within the allotted time. Your two lowest scores are dropped automatically, so the five remaining scores count toward your grade. If you miss a quiz through an excused absence, tell me and we will arrange a make-up rather than spending one of your two drops on it.

Midterm Exam (20%)

In class, Wednesday, October 28. Written by hand, closed book.

Final Exam (20%)

Friday, December 18, 1:00 to 4:00 pm. Written by hand, closed book.

The make-up sitting is Thursday, December 17, 1:00 to 4:00 pm.

REQUIRED TEXTBOOKS

Plato, <i>Republic</i> (Hackett, tr. Grube)	9780872201361
Aristotle, <i>The Nicomachean Ethics</i> (Oxford, tr. Ross)	9780199213610
Aristotle, <i>Politics</i> (Hackett, tr. Reeve)	9780872203884
Epictetus, <i>Handbook</i> (Hackett, tr. White)	9780915145690
Aurelius, <i>Meditations</i> (Oxford, tr. Hard)	9780199573202
<i>The New Oxford Annotated Bible with Apocrypha</i> (Oxford, ed. Coogan)	9780190276089
Augustine, <i>City of God</i> (Penguin, tr. Bettenson)	9780140448948
The Qur'an (Oxford, tr. Haleem)	9780199535958
Ibn Khaldun, <i>The Muqaddimah</i> (Princeton, tr. Rosenthal)	9780691166285
Christine de Pizan, <i>The Book of the City of Ladies</i> (Penguin, tr. Brown-Grant)	9780140446890
Machiavelli, <i>The Prince</i> (Oxford, tr. Bondanella)	9780199535699
Descartes, <i>A Discourse on the Method</i> (Oxford, tr. Maclean)	9780199540075
Hobbes, <i>Leviathan</i> (Norton, ed. Johnston)	9780393532487
Locke, <i>Political Writings</i> (Hackett, ed. Wootton)	9780872206762
Rousseau, <i>The Basic Political Writings</i> (Hackett, tr. Cress)	9781603846738

The books listed above can be purchased through the Columbia University Bookstore. Digital and print copies of most books can be borrowed from Butler Library using CLIO. Please do not use alternate translations and editions as this will lead to inconsistencies and confusion on exams.

Columbia and Barnard FLI Partnership Libraries

Students who identify as first-generation, low-income students may use the [Columbia FLI Partnership Library](#), a collection of textbooks and other course materials available to low-income and/or first-generation students from Columbia University's undergraduate schools. Students may register to borrow materials from the collection for extended loan periods by filling out the confidential [FLI Partnership Libraries Access form](#). The purpose of this form is to create a confidential channel for requesting access to the FLI library, while ensuring that the collection serves its primary audience of FLI undergraduates. Columbia's FLI Partnership library is located in Butler Library. [Barnard also maintains its](#)

[own FLI Partnership Library](#) in Barnard Library, and qualified Columbia undergraduates may similarly borrow from that collection.

Students may access the collection by searching by location for "[Columbia FLI Partnership Library](#)" or "[Barnard FLI Partnership Library](#)" within CLIO. Additionally, they may browse both collections by searching just for "[FLI Partnership Library](#)." Next, students may check out books from our FLI Partnership collections by using the Libraries' pick-up options.

If you are having difficulty obtaining the required texts for any reason, please contact the Center for the Core Curriculum: core-curriculum@columbia.edu.

STUDENT RESOURCES AND SERVICES

Academic Integrity https://www.cc-seas.columbia.edu/academic-integrity Lerner Hall, 6th floor 2920 Broadway New York, NY 10027 ugrad-integrity@columbia.edu (212) 853-1772	Academic Success Programs https://www.cc-seas.columbia.edu/asp 403 Lerner Hall 2920 Broadway asp@columbia.edu (212) 854-3514	Center for the Core Curriculum https://www.college.columbia.edu/core-curriculum 202 Hamilton Hall 1130 Amsterdam Avenue New York, NY 10027 core-curriculum@columbia.edu (212) 854-2543
Center for Student Success and Intervention (CSSI) https://cssi.columbia.edu/ 800 Watson Hall 612 W 115th Street, 8th floor CSSI@columbia.edu (212) 854-6872	Counseling and Psychological Services (Columbia) https://health.columbia.edu/counseling-and-psychological-services Lerner Hall, 5th and 8th Floors 2920 Broadway (212) 854-2878	Disability Services (DS) https://health.columbia.edu/disability-services 108A Wien Hall, main floor 411 W 116th Street disability@columbia.edu (212) 854 2388
Furman Counseling Center (Barnard) https://barnard.edu/health-wellness/student-counseling 100 Hewitt Hall, 1st floor 3009 Broadway counseling@barnard.edu (212) 854-2092	Multicultural Affairs https://www.cc-seas.columbia.edu/OMA Audre Lorde Community Space 505 Lerner Hall 2920 Broadway multicultural@columbia.edu (212) 854-0720	Office of Institutional Equity (including Title IX) https://institutionalequity.columbia.edu/ 80 Claremont Avenue institutionalequity@columbia.edu (212) 854-5511

Public Safety https://publicsafety.columbia.edu/ 101 Low Library 545 W 116th Street publicsafety@columbia.edu EMERGENCY: (212) 854-5555 OFFICE: (212) 854-2797	Religious Life https://religiouslife.columbia.edu/ Earl Hall 2980 Broadway religiouslife@columbia.edu (212) 854-2184	Sexual Violence Response https://health.columbia.edu/content/sexual-violence-response 700 Lerner Hall 2920 Broadway HELPLINE: (212) 854-4357 OFFICE: (212) 854-3500
	Writing Center https://www.college.columbia.edu/core-curriculum/undergraduate-writing-program/writing-center 310 Philosophy Hall 1150 Amsterdam Avenue uwp@columbia.edu (212) 854-3886	

SEMESTER SCHEDULE

The following semester schedule is subject to change. Expect the assignments to evolve throughout the semester. Changes will be announced on CourseWorks and in class.

Readings are to be completed before the session under which they are listed.

Session	Date	Reading and due dates
S1	Wed 9/9	Plato, Republic I. Read before our first meeting; posted to CourseWorks.
S2	Mon 9/14	Plato, Republic II–IV
S3	Wed 9/16	Plato, Republic V–VII
S4	Mon 9/21	Plato, Republic VIII–IX
S5	Wed 9/23	Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics I, II, III, V
S6	Mon 9/28	Aristotle, Politics I (1–7, 12–13), II (1–5), III
S7	Wed 9/30	Epicurus, “Letter to Menoeceus”*; Epictetus, Handbook; Marcus Aurelius, Meditations (selections)
S8	Mon 10/5	Hebrew Bible: Exodus 1–25
S9	Wed 10/7	New Testament: Matthew 1–7, 24–28; Romans 1–13; Galatians
S10	Mon 10/12	Augustine, City of God: Preface; IV.1–4; XII.1–9, 21–23; XIV.1–4, 11–17, 24–28; XV.1, 6–7; XIX.13–17, 24–27
S11	Wed 10/14	The Qur'an: 1, 112, 109, 56, 75, 45, 81, 91–92, 96–97, 99 (Meccan); 2, 4, 20, 19, 12 (Medinan)
S12	Mon 10/19	Ibn Tufayl, “Hayy Ibn Yaqzan”*; Al-Ghazali, “The Rescuer from Error”*

S13	Wed 10/21	Ibn Khaldun, Muqaddimah (selections)
S14	Mon 10/26	Christine de Pizan, The Book of the City of Ladies (selections). ESSAY 1 DUE.
S15	Wed 10/28	MIDTERM EXAM (in class).
—	Mon 11/2	<i>No class. Academic Holiday.</i>
S16	Wed 11/4	Machiavelli, The Prince (complete; you may skip chs. 11–13, but read §§1–2 of ch. 12)
S17	Mon 11/9	Conquest of the Americas: “El Requerimiento”*; The Broken Spears (pp. 3–36, 127–149)*; Vitoria, On the American Indians, qq. 1, 3*; Guamán Poma, “Appeal Concerning the Priests”*
S18	Wed 11/11	Luther: “Preface to Romans”*; “Concerning Governmental Authority”*; “The Twelve Articles”*; “Friendly Admonition to Peace”*
S19	Mon 11/16	Descartes, A Discourse on the Method (you may skip the account of the circulation of the blood, pp. 56–61, up to “reach the brain”)
S20	Wed 11/18	Hobbes, Leviathan chs. 6, 13–16
S21	Mon 11/23	Hobbes, Leviathan chs. 17–21, 29
—	Wed 11/25	<i>No class. Academic Holiday.</i>
S22	Mon 11/30	Locke, Second Treatise, in Political Writings (pp. 261–387)
S23	Wed 12/2	Rousseau, Discourse on the Origins of Inequality (complete, including the Letter to the Republic of Geneva, the Preface, and endnote 15 on amour-propre), in The Basic Political Writings (pp. 29–120)
S24	Mon 12/7	Rousseau, On the Social Contract, Books I–II entire; III.1–4, 15; IV.1–2, 8, in The Basic Political Writings (pp. 153–252)
S25	Wed 12/9	Synthesis and review.
S26	Mon 12/14	Writing workshop. Last day of classes.

- *Fri 12/18* *FINAL EXAM, 1:00–4:00 pm. Core-wide common exam. Make-up sitting Thu 12/17, 1:00–4:00 pm.*

- *Tue 12/22* *ESSAY 2 DUE.*